

Reopening the Riverside Footbridge - Core Meaning Practice

A longer mixed-skill passage set with closer answer choices and no teaching during the attempt.

GED Practice - Core Meaning

Suggested time: 12-15 minutes. Read the passage, answer all questions, and check explanations only after you finish.

For decades, the Riverside Footbridge gave residents of Glen Park a short route across the Willow River to the public library, bus terminal, and shopping district. After an inspection found corrosion in several steel connections, the city closed the bridge to pedestrians. The closure was inconvenient: the nearest alternate crossing added almost twenty minutes to the walk for some residents. Still, engineers warned that keeping the bridge open while its condition was uncertain would create an unnecessary safety risk.

The first inspection did not show that the entire bridge had failed. Most of the concrete deck remained in acceptable condition, and several support members showed only normal wear. The most serious corrosion appeared at connection points where water had collected for years. Engineers therefore recommended a staged response. Before the city decided whether to replace the whole structure, workers would remove damaged material, strengthen the affected connections, improve drainage, and then test the repaired sections.

Some residents expected the bridge to reopen as soon as visible rust was removed. The engineering department explained that appearance alone could not show whether a connection was strong enough. After repairs, crews used load tests and sensors to measure how the structure responded when weight was placed on different

sections. The city also required an independent engineer who had not designed the repair to review the results.

The tests showed that the strengthened connections met the required limits, but they also identified two smaller areas that needed additional work. Those repairs delayed reopening by three weeks. During that time, the city added temporary lighting and signs to the alternate walking route. The transportation department also adjusted one local bus schedule so that residents who could not comfortably make the longer walk had another option.

When the bridge finally reopened, the city did not treat the project as finished. Engineers scheduled inspections every six months for the first two years instead of returning immediately to the older, less frequent schedule. Small moisture sensors were left near several repaired connections. If those sensors showed repeated water buildup, maintenance crews would inspect the drainage system before the next scheduled review.

The repair project also changed the city's long-term planning. A full replacement may still be needed in the future because some parts of the bridge are more than seventy years old. However, the staged repair restored the crossing while giving planners time to study replacement costs, accessibility improvements, and possible changes to the river path below.

For residents, the most visible result was simple: the shortcut was available again. For the city, the larger lesson was that reopening safely required more than removing visible damage. The process combined targeted repair, testing, independent review, temporary transportation measures, and continued monitoring after pedestrians returned.

Questions

1. Why did the city keep the bridge closed after the first repairs were completed?

- A. Residents had requested a permanent closure.
- B. The alternate walking route was shorter than the bridge.
- C. The city had already decided to replace the bridge immediately.
- D. Engineers still needed load testing, sensor measurements, and an independent review to confirm that the repaired structure met safety requirements.

2. Which statement best expresses the central idea of the passage?

- A. The city reopened the bridge mainly because residents were unhappy with the longer walking route.
- B. Reopening the bridge safely required a staged process of targeted repair, testing, independent review, temporary access measures, and continued monitoring rather than a quick cosmetic fix.
- C. The bridge should have been fully replaced as soon as corrosion was found.
- D. Moisture sensors are more important than structural inspections for old bridges.

3. Which detail best supports the idea that the city's decisions were based on evidence rather than the bridge's appearance?

- A. Residents could see rust on several connections.
- B. The concrete deck remained in acceptable condition.
- C. Engineers used load tests and sensors after repairs, and an independent engineer reviewed the results before reopening.
- D. The bridge was more than seventy years old.

4. Which choice best summarizes the section about what happened after the first round of repairs?

- A. Testing showed the main repairs met limits but revealed two additional areas needing work, delaying reopening while the city also supported residents using the alternate route.
- B. The bridge reopened immediately after visible rust was removed.
- C. The city cancelled all bus service until the bridge could reopen.
- D. Independent review showed that every part of the bridge needed complete replacement.

5. Which statement best summarizes the passage?

- A. A historic bridge was closed because residents preferred walking to the library by bus.
- B. The city replaced a bridge after an inspection showed that the entire structure had failed.
- C. The city removed visible corrosion, reopened the bridge, and ended its monitoring program.
- D. After corrosion was found, the city used staged repairs, testing, temporary transportation measures, and continued monitoring to restore the crossing while planning for longer-term needs.

6. Which statement is directly supported about monitoring after the bridge reopened?

- A. The city returned immediately to its older, less frequent inspection schedule.
- B. The city scheduled inspections every six months for the first two years and left moisture sensors near repaired connections.
- C. Monitoring would stop as soon as replacement costs were estimated.
- D. Only residents were responsible for reporting water buildup.

7. Which detail best supports the idea that the repair gave the city time to plan for future needs instead of settling every long-term issue?

- A. The bridge provided a shortcut to the library and bus terminal.
- B. Temporary lighting was added to the alternate route.
- C. A full replacement may still be needed, but the staged repair restored access while planners study replacement costs, accessibility, and river-path changes.
- D. The first inspection found corrosion at connection points.

Answer key & reasoning

1. D - R1.1

The passage directly explains that visible repair was not enough; testing and independent review were required.

Use again: Keep the stated safety process separate from later replacement planning.

2. B - R1.2

Choice B explains the full process and matches the concluding idea that safe reopening required more than removing visible damage.

Use again: Use the final paragraph as a check, but make sure the answer also fits the earlier sections.

3. C - R1.3

Choice C directly shows objective testing and independent review determining readiness rather than visible appearance.

Use again: Strong support should connect directly to the exact contrast in the claim.

4. A - R1.4

The section includes successful testing, discovery of two smaller problems, a delay, and temporary transportation support.

Use again: A good section summary keeps the main result and its consequence.

5. D - R1.4

Choice D captures the closure, staged response, safe reopening, support during delay, and ongoing planning.

Use again: A whole-passage summary should include the major process and future limitation without listing every technical detail.

6. B - R1.1

The passage directly states the six-month schedule and continued sensor placement.

Use again: Preserve the time period and monitoring method exactly.

7. C - R1.3

Choice C directly links restored access with unresolved future planning.

Use again: Choose the detail that supports both the immediate result and unfinished long-term planning.

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